CASH TO COMPANY · STRATEGIC REFERENCE

a FlexLifeFi K-12 program

Cash & Company

MASTER · CHARACTER & VOICE

Cash Mascot Style Guide

The locked rules for how Cash speaks – across thirteen grades.

Visual identity, voice calibration by grade band, the things Cash never says, and the sensitivity protocols that protect every classroom this lands in.

CASH MASCOT STYLE GUIDE

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> One coin. Thirteen years. One question that never changes.

CASH MASCOT STYLE GUIDE

Cash is the program's animated host and mascot. Cash appears in short videos at the top of each unit, in classroom-facing graphics, and in occasional asides in the Student Activity Books. This style guide defines who Cash is, how Cash sounds, what Cash does, and what Cash never does.

The guide is intended for: scriptwriters, animators, voice talent, classroom-facing graphic designers, and any member of the Cash to Company curriculum team writing in Cash's voice.

1. Who Cash is

Identity. Cash is the program's animated host — a friendly, coin-shaped character with a warm but not babyish presence. Cash is gender-neutral. Cash is not human; Cash is "of the program," like a class pet that talks. Cash is roughly the same age year-to-year — but Cash's voice and language shift across grade bands (more on that in Section 4).

Role. Cash is a guide, not a teacher. Cash poses questions that point students toward evidence; Cash does not give answers. Cash never tells students what to do; Cash asks what their evidence says.

Personality core, in five words: curious, warm, honest, patient, specific.

What Cash is fundamentally about: the question which people, and how do you know? That sentence is the spine of Cash's character. Every Cash appearance is, at some level, asking that question.

2. What Cash looks like (visual identity, brief)

A coin-shaped character (think a 2D circle with simple features), warm-toned but not over-bright. Cash has a face that can express attention, curiosity, mild surprise — never extreme excitement, never sadness, never cynicism. Cash often holds a small notebook or clipboard. Cash is drawn in a way that signals "we made this with care, not a marketing budget" — hand-drawn or paper-cutout aesthetic preferred over slick 3D rendering.

Color palette stays muted (no neon). The look should feel approachable across grade bands without skewing too "kindergarten."

3. How Cash sounds

VOICE CHARACTERISTICS

- **Calm, not hyper.** Cash's energy is "thoughtful older sibling," not "TV presenter."
- **Specific, not vague.** Cash names actual numbers, actual quotes, actual examples.
- **Inquisitive, not declarative.** Cash often ends statements with questions, even rhetorical ones.

- **Warm, not gushing.** Cash never says "great job!" or "amazing!" Cash says "okay, good — what's the evidence?"
- **Honest, not sugary.** Cash names hard things directly. "You're going to be wrong on Day 1. That's the deal."

SAMPLE SENTENCES IN CASH'S VOICE

✓ "Most adults skip this. You won't." ✓ "You don't have to know everything. You have to know one number." ✓ "Being wrong is the deal." ✓ "Which people, and how do you know?" ✓ "Don't make up a winner. Decide what to test next." ✓ "Revenue is loud. Contribution margin is true." ✓ "Tell me what they actually said."

PHRASES CASH NEVER SAYS

× "Anyone can be a millionaire!" × "The sky's the limit!" × "Believe in yourself!" (as a substitute for evidence) × "Easy money." × "If you can dream it, you can do it." × "Money is fun!" (as a stand-alone framing) × "Awesome!" / "Crushing it!" / "Boss up!" × "Just do it." (Cash always says try and test, not just do.) × Any phrase implying that wealth is purely a matter of mindset or hustle. × Any phrase implying that students from low-income or unbanked families are at fault. × Any wealth-flexing language ("when you're rolling in cash," "imagine you have a yacht").

CASH'S GO-TO VERBS

Notice. Ask. Listen. Test. Check. Try. Revise. Decide. Specify. Name.

CASH'S GO-TO QUESTION STEMS

- "Which people, and how do you know?"
- "What did they actually say?"
- "What does your evidence tell you?"
- "What would have to be true for you to be right?"
- "What would have to be true for you to be wrong?"
- "What's one thing you'd change?"
- "How would you know if you were getting better?"

4. Voice across grade bands

Cash adjusts vocabulary and pacing across the four grade bands but stays the same character. The personality and core question never change. What changes is the words used to ask the question.

K-2 CASH

- Sentences are short. 6–10 words each.
- Concrete examples only. Coins, snacks, helpers in the community.
- No abstractions. No "evidence" — instead, "what did you see?"

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- Repetition is friendly. Cash repeats key words ("notice, notice, notice").
- Sample line: "What did the helper do? Tell me what you saw with your eyes."

3-5 CASH

- Sentences a bit longer. 10–15 words.
- Vocabulary expands: customer, problem, plan, profit.
- Cash starts asking "what's your evidence" but in plain words: "how do you know that?"
- Sample line: "You picked this idea. How do you know somebody actually wants it?"

6-8 CASH

- Full sentences, occasional complex ones.
- Vocabulary expands: customer, persona, contribution margin, A/B test, signal vs. noise.
- Cash uses honest, slightly irreverent asides. "Most adults skip this. You won't."
- Cash starts naming its own uncertainty: "I don't know either. That's why we test."
- Sample line: "Revenue is loud. Contribution margin is true. Compute one number this week."

9-12 CASH

- Sentences and arguments are full-shaped — Cash can build a 5-sentence point.
- Vocabulary expands: unit economics, runway, premortem, segmentation, MVP.
- Cash gets directly philosophical sometimes: "You can pick what kind of business you build. It's a choice."
- Cash names systemic factors honestly when relevant: "Some of this is hard because the world's hard. The skill is knowing what's in your hands."
- Sample line: "You'll meet adults who skipped this part and got lucky. Don't model your career on luck. Model it on the moves."

5. What Cash does

CASH POSES QUESTIONS

The dominant move. Cash asks questions that direct students to their own evidence. Cash does not answer for them.

CASH NAMES RULES

Occasionally, Cash names a clean rule. "An assumption is something you think is true without checking. Evidence is something you observed, heard, or counted." Rules are useful when they're sharp; Cash uses them sparingly.

CASH TELLS SHORT STORIES

Cash often opens videos with a 30–60 second story (always made up, always realistic). Stories show, don't tell. "Here's a story I made up to be true. A kid runs a bracelet business..."

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CASH CELEBRATES THE RIGHT THINGS

Not the win. The move. "You didn't make money this year. That's the win. You did the work." Cash celebrates evidence, revision, and honesty — not revenue, popularity, or impressiveness.

CASH NAMES DIFFICULTY HONESTLY

"This is going to be hard. The hard part is the point." Cash never papers over difficulty with cheerleading.

CASH MODIFIES ITS OWN CLAIMS

Cash uses hedges deliberately: "probably, often, in most cases, sometimes." Cash never speaks in absolutes about complex topics.

CASH RETURNS TO THE YEAR'S QUESTION

Almost every Cash appearance circles back to which people, and how do you know? — sometimes explicitly, sometimes implicitly. The question is the program's spine; Cash is its mouth.

6. What Cash does NOT do

CASH DOES NOT FLATTER

Cash never says "great job," "amazing," "you're so smart." Cash gives precise, content-relevant feedback: "Okay, that's specific. What's the evidence?"

CASH DOES NOT PROMISE OUTCOMES

Cash never promises wealth, success, or that the student's venture will work. Cash promises only that the moves — interview, math, message, listen — will make the student less wrong over time.

CASH DOES NOT MORALIZE ABOUT MONEY

Cash does not say money is good or bad. Money is a tool. Cash treats it neutrally — what matters is what students do with it and how honestly they do it.

CASH DOES NOT REFERENCE REAL BRANDS OR LIVING CELEBRITIES

Cash uses fictional businesses ("a bracelet stand," "a snack box"). Cash references real founders only via established public stories, never in ways that endorse a specific company today. (E.g., okay: "Here's how Spanx started." Not okay: "Buy from Spanx.")

CASH DOES NOT ENGAGE WITH POLITICS, RELIGION, OR CURRENT EVENTS

Cash is curriculum-neutral. Cash will reference economic concepts (supply, demand, cost) but not policy debates (taxes-are-bad, regulation-is-good).

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CASH DOES NOT SURFACE FAMILY FINANCIAL DETAILS

Cash never asks students about their family income, family debts, family banking status. Cash uses neutral hypothetical scenarios.

CASH DOES NOT SAY "EVERYONE CAN BE RICH"

The program rejects the meritocratic-mindset framing entirely. Cash explicitly does not promise wealth as a result of effort. Cash says, instead: "You'll be a clearer thinker about money no matter what you end up doing."

CASH DOES NOT PRETEND THE WORLD IS FAIR

At higher grade bands, Cash will say plainly: "Some of this is hard because the world's hard. Wage gaps, geography, and luck shape what people can do. The skill we're building is the skill that's actually in your hands." Cash is honest about systemic factors without becoming a politics class.

CASH DOES NOT BREAK CHARACTER

Cash never references "the curriculum," "the lesson," "your teacher said," etc. Cash exists in the program's universe and stays there. The teacher is the live human doing the teaching; Cash is the persistent voice connecting concepts.

7. Cash's relationship to other roles

CASH AND THE TEACHER

Cash is not a substitute for the teacher. Cash introduces concepts and poses questions; the teacher does the live work. If a student asks the teacher "what does Cash say?" the teacher should redirect: "What does your evidence say?"

CASH AND THE PARENT

Cash is a family-friendly figure — parents who watch a Cash video should feel comfortable that nothing manipulative or pushy is happening. The Parent Guide explicitly notes that Cash is curious and warm, never sells or promises.

CASH AND THE STUDENT

Cash is on the student's side. Cash takes their work seriously. Cash is patient with mistakes — "Being wrong is the deal." Cash never condescends. The student is the protagonist; Cash is a curious co-traveler.

CASH AND THE PROGRAM

Cash is the spine. As students move K to 12, Cash is the constant. By Grade 12, students should feel a sense of having "grown up with" Cash — and Cash should feel like an old friend whose questions have gotten more interesting alongside them.

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8. Cash phrases by unit (the canon)

These are the lines Cash returns to year after year. They are the program's signature phrases.

- **The opening question:** "Which people, and how do you know?"
- **The Day 1 frame:** "Being wrong on Day 1 is the deal."
- **The math frame:** "Revenue is loud. Contribution margin is true."
- **The messaging frame:** "Honest claims build customers who come back. Tricks build customers who feel taken."
- **The feedback frame:** "Listening is not a moment. It's a system."
- **The growth frame:** "A little less wrong, every week."
- **The closing frame:** "Don't sell. Show."

When in doubt, work one of these phrases into the script.

9. Tone calibration: the four common failure modes

Cash should feel pulled equally away from all four of these:

- **The hype-bro.** "BOSS UP! GET THAT BAG!" — Cash is not this. Ever.
- **The overly cute mascot.** Singing dollar signs, "money mountain," "savings sloth." Cash is not this. The brand is substance, not adorability.
- **The corporate trainer.** "Today we will be exploring the concept of contribution margin." — Cash is warmer and more specific than this.
- **The lecturing parent.** "When I was your age, I had to walk to school in the snow." — Cash never moralizes. Cash never compares generations.

If a draft sounds like any of those four, rewrite.

10. Approval / review process

Every Cash script and graphic should be reviewed against this guide before production. A simple review checklist:

- [ ] Does Cash sound calm, curious, warm — not hyped, not babyish, not corporate?
- [ ] Does Cash pose at least one evidence-pointing question?
- [ ] Are all examples concrete (not abstract)?
- [ ] Are claims hedged appropriately (no absolutes)?
- [ ] Is the language age-appropriate for the target band?
- [ ] Is there any phrase Cash would never say (flattery, promise, money-as-easy)?
- [ ] Does the script end with a clear classroom CTA?
- [ ] Is the runtime within target (2:30–3:00 for video; 30–60 sec for shorts)?
- [ ] Is the visual aesthetic warm-but-not-slick?

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- [ ] Is Cash gender-neutral throughout?

If any item is no, revise.

11. A note on the brand promise

Cash to Company makes one promise: that students who move through the program will be clearer thinkers about money and entrepreneurship — no matter what they end up doing for a living. The program does not promise wealth. It does not promise success. It promises clarity.

Cash is the voice of that promise. When in doubt about a script, ask: does this line make the student a clearer thinker, or does it make them feel a feeling? Clarity over feeling is the rule.

One promise.

One coin. Thirteen years. One question that never changes.

Cash to Company is built so a curriculum coordinator, a foundation officer, a parent, or a teacher can pick up any one of these strategic references and meet the program at full strength on the first page.

No promise of wealth. No probing of family finances. No partisan content. One question, asked patiently for thirteen years: which people, and how do you know?

For educational and operational use. This document is informational and does not constitute financial, legal, or tax advice. Standards alignment is cited per the Cash to Company Standards Alignment Map (Jump$tart, CEE, CCSS, C3, CASEL, NGSS-ETS).